

INVENTORY • STACK • STRUCTURE

cards-stack

Parallel items stacked vertically, full-width cards.

Three forces are compressing the differentiation window.

Infrastructure has commoditized.

The platform work that took us two years is now a managed service a competitor can switch on in an afternoon. The moat is no longer the stack.

Release cycles have collapsed.

What used to ship annually now ships monthly. A visible advantage is matched before the next board meeting.

Switching costs are rising.

Customers consolidate vendors and sign longer contracts. The window to win an account is shorter, and losing one lasts longer.

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Three patterns, each with its own pull.

Inventory.

Equal-weight items the audience scans without ordering. The cards-grid family lives here — grid, stack, wide, side.

Comparison.

Two or more items weighed against shared criteria. The verdict and compare families live here — they take sides.

Progression.

Items that carry an explicit sequence. The list-steps and timeline families live here — order is load-bearing.

Three reasons to keep cards-stack at three items.

1

Cognitive load

Three is the threshold the audience can hold without effort. Past three, the slide demands working memory the room shouldn't have to spend.

2

Vertical real estate

Each stacked card needs ~30% of the slide height to breathe. Four cards force you to shrink the cards until they stop reading as cards.

3

Build path symmetry

cards-stack pairs with cards-grid (3-4 grid items) and cards-side (exactly 2). Keeping cards-stack at 2-4 keeps the family's choices clean.

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When NOT to reach for cards-stack.

Four or more items. The stack overflows past four. For five or more rows reach for list-tabular.

One-line cards. If each card is a single short phrase, the stack reads as a padded list. Drop to `list` or `tldr` and reclaim the vertical space.

Forced sequence. Cards-stack is parallel content read in vertical order, not a numbered sequence. For explicit steps, use list-steps or list-criteria.

See also.

RELATED COMPONENTS

`cards-grid` — three or four parallel items in a scannable grid

`cards-side` — exactly two items in left-right balance

`list-steps` — items carry an explicit, ordered sequence